

ARCHITECTURE / By ROBERT CAMPBELL

Library is fine by itself, but...

Last week, at a ceremony at the Parker House, Sen. Edward M. Kennedy unveiled the architect's model of the Kennedy Presidential Library to be built in Cambridge.

Reviewing a building, as *The Globe* has asked this columnist to do, is a little disconcerting. It doesn't make much sense to treat a building as you would a book or movie. No one needs a review to tell him whether to see or buy a building.

Worse yet, no one can define where a building begins or ends. It doesn't have a frame around it, like a painting, and it doesn't last only 90 minutes or so, like a movie. Both those other art forms can be looked at without worrying about their distracting surroundings. But in the case of a building, its relationship to its distracting surroundings is likely to be the most important thing about it.

Certainly that is turning out to be true of I.M. Pei's Kennedy Library.

As originally designed, the library appeared to many people to be turning its back on its surroundings, gathering itself protectively around a quiet interior courtyard that faced the river.

The architect spoke of "defensive" design that would prevent unwelcome "intrusions." But intrusions came anyway, from an unexpected source, in the form of a rising volume of criticism from the vocal Cambridge community. Quickly, the issue became one of what the building was going to do to the city, rather than the quality of the building itself.

Before the library gets completely buried in a shuffle of contending arguments, it might be a good idea to look at it for a moment just as a building.

I.M. Pei — whose other work here includes the new Christian Science Center and the somewhat notorious John Hancock Building — has been taking quite a beating from the Boston press, a lot of it sounding like the jibes of a smalltown redneck watching the big-city slicker trip up. It's only fair to point out, therefore, that the Kennedy Library, at the very least, is an extremely sophisticated and intriguing design that will undoubtedly be a pleasure to experience.

The complex has two parts: a long, low background building that forms three sides of a square (curved on the inside), and a pyramidal glass pavilion. The whole thing still faces away from Harvard Square and toward the river, but it has a broad new opening passing beneath the building leading up toward Brattle Square.

A visitor, entering from either direction, arrives in the curved central courtyard, then climbs broad steps to a higher terrace with a view of the Charles. The visitor then turns left and enters the 50-foot-high glass pyramid.

This element has been added to the design since it was first presented last fall; it gives the complex

a focus and a signature on the Charles River skyline.

More puzzling is the fact that the pyramid doesn't have much in it. It is a kind of environmental sculpture without a function; its purpose, say the designers, is to be a place for contemplation. Dominating the interior is a huge triangular object known to the architects as the kite. One point of the kite rests on the floor near the center of the space and the kite then rises, sloping forward and getting wider, all the 50 or so feet to the ridge of the pyramid. Like the pyramid itself, the kite serves no useful purpose, and one may conjecture that the architect is trying to create an experience in contemporary, secular terms that is analogous to that of a chapel.

When the visitor is finished contemplating, or being mystified as the case may be, he descends an escalator to the two levels of museum buried in the solid podium of the pyramid. These contain films and exhibits on President Kennedy. From the lower level he emerges again into the courtyard, looking across it toward the curving, non-glass portion of the complex, which houses the archives and Institute of Politics, open to scholars but not the public.

Allowing for the fact that the design is still at a very early stage, the Kennedy Library — viewed in isolation — deserves admiration for its skill in pulling a variety of functions into a convincing, original and powerful composition.

But there's the rub. As noted above, a building isn't a painting or film, and "viewed in isolation" is exactly what it can't and shouldn't be. And that's where the questions begin.

Why would anyone want to dump a national tourist mecca two blocks from the most congested intersection in Greater Boston?

Why is the complex turned at 45 degrees to the street pattern, causing it to eat up the largest possible area of its site?

What will happen to Harvard Square? Will the Kennedy complex, with hordes of tourists, bring too much pressure for high-rise commercial development of the square? Already a Holiday Inn is planned, with many other "improvements" being actively promoted. Will these changes forever alter the pedestrian, small-scale, university-oriented quality of the square?

Why can't the complex, on so large a site include some shops or restaurants or apartments to give the area life at night and return some taxes to the city?

Most of all, why can't the Kennedy Library help solve an already horrendous parking problem, instead of making it worse?

But while all these questions hang fire, the library moves inexorably toward a construction start next spring, and there isn't much its opponents can do to stop it. The possibility remains strong that the problems the Kennedy Library may create for Cambridge will be solved after it gets built, not before — if they are solved at all.

